

■ Commandos

Pyro's *Commandos* ranks as one of the most memorable games in the tactical strategy genre. The game is a combination of single and multi-squad campaigns in which you have to manage Dirty Dozen-type special agents during infiltration missions in World War II. At every situation, you have to be constantly aware of the consequences. Playing a mission is like figuring out a puzzle and it takes many retries before one would finally get it all together. While *Commandos* may not win any awards for its graphics, it's great to see the aesthetic value and the attention paid to detail. It works smoothly on the leanest of machines—a Pentium 166 will do just fine.

■ Homeworld

A terrific story, amazing narrative, mystery, and surprises at every turn. In a genre (real time strategy or RTS) notorious for being boring and predictable, *Homeworld* is revolutionary. The story is of a colony struggling to find its home and roots. Equipped with hyperspace capabilities, you take a massive colony of people in search of their home, only to run smack into a swarm of hostile aliens. You have to guide your fleet through a series of 16 missions by building more vessels, researching new technologies, and harvesting resources in the voyage to your Homeworld.

The 3D engine is stunning and the attention to detail is simply staggering. The interface is very intuitive, though the three-axes movement may be a little tricky.

■ Command and Conquer Red Alert 2

The C&C series deserve the credit for taking RTS to a mainstream level. If you had to pick one more title to add to your shopping list, it would have to be *Red Alert*, the best of the C&C games and one of the greatest strategy games ever made. C&C has a fiction-meets-the-real-world type of story line, where Einstein invents a time machine and using it, kidnaps Hitler to prevent the outbreak of World War II. Though early versions of C&C were strongly single-player based, later versions began to explore the multi-player options and more specifically, the skirmish mode. That's because the AI gets predictable after a while and is not able to put up much of a fight against a human. A single skirmish can take several hours to complete, especially when both the opponents are evenly matched.

■ Half-Life

No game has come this close to capturing public imagination and the critic's mind alike. The story line was genuinely scary, and the interaction with non-playing characters (NPCs) such as scientists made the game seem much more real.

Half-Life didn't just raise the bar for PC gaming, it obliterated it. Hard to believe, but this first game by a couple of Microsoft millionaires brought about many staggering innovations to FPS games: skeletal animation, intelligent AI, great story telling, NPCs, map and mod support. In the single-player game, you play Gordon Freeman, a research scientist working in a secret government lab with strange alien materials. Very early on, disaster strikes and you have to fend off alien attackers and the US military. The plot, though rigidly linear, serves its purpose admirably. *Half-Life* has deservedly won over 50 'Game of the year' awards from publications and print magazines worldwide.

■ Unreal Tournament

When *Unreal Tournament* (UT) was released in 1999, everyone drew a comparison to *Quake III*, and in many review sites, UT was the more popular choice.

The UT bots were far more skilled than the ones *Quake III* had, and with a feature called auto-adjust skill, the bots could match the average skill set of the player they were currently engaging. UT followed the everything-but-the-kitchen-sink philosophy, having game types such as Tournament DeathMatch,

Assault, Domination, Capture The Flag, and Last Man Standing as the standard package.

UT has a markedly inferior 3D engine than *Quake III* in terms of raw power and capability. This conversely makes the game run acceptably on older PC hardware in software mode. Besides, UT has the ability to render extremely large maps without choking your video card.

■ Quake III

id software has always set standards in terms of graphics. Curved surfaces, reflections, environment mapping and volumetric fog—*Quake III* was the first graphics engine to enable curves to be created, rather than lots of polygon flat shapes placed close together.

This game has been the basis for many other retail games such as *Star Trek: Elite Force*, and American McGee's *Alice*. *Return to Castle Wolfenstein* uses a modified version of the *Quake III* engine. *Quake III* is the reason people buy graphics cards, and these graphics cards lead to better games, and better games need better graphics cards. The gaming industry would have been significantly different today if not for *Quake*. ■

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